

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Ceasefire, hostage deal in ‘final stage’

Insiders say Hamas has accepted draft as sides remain hopeful

By Samy Magdy and Wafaa Shurafa
Associated Press

CAIRO — Hamas has accepted a draft agreement for a ceasefire in the Gaza Strip and the release of dozens of hostages, two officials involved in the talks said Tuesday. Mediators for the United States and Qatar said Israel and the Palestinian militant group were at the closest point yet to sealing a deal to bring them a step closer to ending 15 months of war.

The Associated Press obtained

a copy of the proposed agreement, and an Egyptian official and a Hamas official confirmed its authenticity. An Israeli official said progress has been made, but the details are being finalized. All three officials spoke on condition of anonymity.

“I believe we will get a ceasefire,” U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken said during a speech Tuesday, asserting it was up to Hamas. “It’s right on the brink. It’s closer than it’s ever been before,” and word could come within hours, or days.

The United States, Egypt and Qatar have spent the past year trying to mediate an end to the war and secure the release of dozens of hostages captured in Hamas’ Oct.

7, 2023, attack that triggered it. Nearly 100 people are still captive inside Gaza, and the military believes at least a third are dead.

Any deal is expected to pause the fighting and bring hopes for winding down the most deadly and destructive war Israel and Hamas have ever fought, a conflict that has destabilized the Middle East and sparked worldwide protests.

It would bring relief to the hard-hit Gaza Strip, where Israel’s offensive has reduced large areas to rubble and displaced around 90% of the population of 2.3 million, many at risk of famine.

If a deal is reached, it would not go into effect immediately. The

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A man walks past a graffiti in Jerusalem on Monday that displays portraits of hostages held by Hamas in Gaza. **OHAD ZWIGENBERG/AP**



BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

POINT WELL TAKEN

Naomi Klionsky climbs out of Lake Michigan after taking a chilly dip while Betsy Mensah looks at ice shards on Tuesday at Promontory Point. According to the Promontory Point Conservancy, the limestone revetment at Promontory Point can be preserved and rehabilitated rather than replaced with concrete. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL

Ex-speaker grilled over comments on Cullerton

Wraps up fourth day of testimony in public corruption proceedings

By Jason Meisner, Megan Crepeau and Ray Long
Chicago Tribune

In November 2018, then-House Speaker Michael Madigan had reason to celebrate: His nemesis Gov. Bruce Rauner, a Republican whose face was on a punching bag in Madigan’s office, had been defeated by a Democrat.

And when Madigan met with Gov.-elect JB Pritzker, he got to score some points against a rival within his own camp — John Cullerton, the then-president of the Illinois Senate.

“I think it went pretty well,” Madigan said on a call with longtime confidante Michael McClain, whose phone had been secretly wiretapped by federal agents. “... I put the knife into Cullerton three or four times.”

Cullerton, a fellow Chicago Democrat, had developed a touchy relationship with Madigan, but, as

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The White House’s incoming border czar, Tom Homan, seen at an event in December, has designated Chicago as ground zero for his plans to round up illegal immigrants. **JOSH EDELSON/GETTY-AFP**

Trump’s pledge of mass deportations could test city’s immigrant protections

By Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

President-elect Donald Trump’s vow to enact mass deportations — and his famous antipathy toward Chicago — have girded local immigration activists for the immediate aftermath of his inauguration.

But how would such an effort, which has not happened before in modern U.S. history, actually unfold? And how real are Trump’s threats to try to go after asylum-seekers, natural-

ized citizens and other groups on top of immigrants in the U.S. without legal permission?

Trump border czar Tom Homan has designated the nation’s third-largest city as ground zero for his plans to round up immigrants in the country illegally and other groups at an unprecedented scale, saber-rattling that could set up a high-profile showdown between progressive Mayor Brandon Johnson and the incoming Republican administration.

Chicago officials are mobilizing a legal and resource playbook to stop federal immigration agents from carrying out raids at businesses, shelters, police lock-ups and beyond.

It’s unclear what exactly the president-elect will do after his Jan. 20 inauguration, as he promised mass deportations before his first term, too, and they largely did not materialize. Still, local leaders told the

Turn to Deport, Page 2

EPA flags sludge used as fertilizer on farms

Northeast Illinois particularly exposed to toxic forever chemicals

By Michael Hawthorne
Chicago Tribune

Farmers who use sewage sludge as fertilizer and their neighbors face higher risks of cancer and other diseases, according to a new federal analysis that pins the blame on toxic forever chemicals.

The findings are particularly relevant for northeast Illinois, where more than 777,000 tons of sludge from Chicago and Cook County have been spread on farmland during the past eight years — in many cases near residential areas.

Only the Greater Los Angeles area distributed more sludge to farmers during the same period.

Officials at the Metropolitan Water Reclamation District of Greater Chicago have known their sludge fertilizer is contaminated with forever chemicals since at least 2011, the Chicago Tribune reported in a 2022 investigation.

Yet the chemicals — also known as per- and polyfluoroalkyl substances or PFAS — are not regulated in sludge fertilizer by the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency. The EPA continues to promote the spread of fetid muck on farmland without limiting the amount of PFAS it contains.

Those policies could change as a result of the agency’s new analysis, published Tuesday in what the EPA calls a draft risk assessment. It could take years to adopt enforceable restrictions, though.

“We know everyone is overexposed to these chemicals,” said David Andrews, acting senior scientist at the Environmental Working Group, a nonprofit research organization that has studied PFAS and advocated for federal regulations since the early 2000s. “This report shows we need prompt action to ensure sludge is free of PFAS so it doesn’t continue to contaminate (livestock) feed and crops.”

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INSIDE

Chairman lays out vision for the RTA

The transit authority proposes more bus and train service, fare hikes and stronger central agency as lawmakers prepare to debate future of transit. **Business**

The degrees of losing for the Blackhawks



With embarrassing loss after embarrassing loss, is the team’s rebuild leaving emotional wreckage?

Phil Thompson in Chicago Sports

